

Chapter 3: The Deep Azure

Nerys, 13 Years Ago

“Tag! Now *you*’ve got the Shadowrot!” The energetic voice of Kraekon echoed through the yard. Nerys had been in the kitchen, cleaning up to prepare for dinner, while Kraekon and Ember played outside. She sighed; Eric was at work, as usual, which meant it was up to her to step in here. She hung up the towel she was using and walked outside.

“Kraekon, come over here for a minute.” The child stopped what he was doing and came over obediently; Nerys couldn’t stop herself from smiling. He was larger and healthier than she’d been at his age, and he was so full of energy that she felt silly she’d ever doubted he’d be alright. “Sweetie,” she began. “Where did you hear that word?”

“What word?”

“Shadowrot.” Kraekon’s face contorted as he tried to think.

“Ummm... I don’t remember?” Nerys sighed. *Oh well.*

“Listen, sweetie. I think you should call this game something different. The Shadowrot isn’t something you should play around with.”

“Why not?” Nerys took a deep breath. Trying to explain this to a child wouldn’t be easy, but it could be very important.

“Shadowrot is a very scary disease that has hurt a lot of people. If you get sick with the Shadowrot, it’s going to make you very, very sick. And then you die. It’s not something to joke about or play around with.” Kraekon tilted his head, considering this. Over in the corner of the yard, Ember had plopped onto the dirt and was drawing something with their finger.

“Mama, what is dying?” Nerys stopped for a moment, taken by surprise.

“Well, dying is... it’s when you leave the world behind. Mama, Papa, Ember—if you died, everyone else would be very sad, because we couldn’t come with you. You’d be all alone, forever.”

“That sounds scary.”

“Oh, it is. It’s scary and sad and lonely, but it’s also very peaceful. My mother called it falling into the deep azure. All around you, there’s nothing—just the deepest blue color. And as you float there, the blue just closes in on you, like a warm hug all over you. There’s no more to worry about, no more pain or sadness. The ones who really hurt are the ones who

are left behind. When someone you love dies, you can't spend time with them; you can't play with them or care for them or laugh with them. There's a hole left inside you, which is why the Shadowrot is so bad; it leaves a lot of people with a lot of holes. Does that make sense?" Nerys worried that it'd be too much for Kraekon, but he seemed to be following along.

"I think so. I'm sorry, Mama. I won't say that anymore. Can you come play with Emby and me?" Kraekon's face seemed introspective, like he was reflecting on what she'd just said. Nerys smiled at her son.

"Of course, sweetie. Let me go put my shoes on and we can play for a little while."

Looking back, Nerys was glad she'd had that conversation with Kraekon. It was only a few days later that Nerys heard the news: one of the food warehouses had developed a leak. One of the warehouses her distributary used.

A lot of people got sick because of it—early estimates guessed nearly a hundred people. A hundred deaths, just because of a leaky roof. And one of them—one of those deaths—was the woman now lying peacefully in front of her. Selene's last few weeks had been horrible. So much pain and suffering, and for nothing. There was no reason, no sense or logic—she'd just been unlucky enough to eat some contaminated food a single time.

A part of Nerys felt guilty about it; maybe she could have caught the leak herself if she'd been working more. Ever since Kraekon was born, she'd cut back on her hours. Eric had disagreed; he said that this tragedy was no one's fault, that the blame lay solely on the darkness. Nerys still couldn't shake the feeling, though, and had spent much of the last few weeks at Selene's house, taking care of her and her family while they tried to make the most of her last drop of time.

In the end, though, there was nothing she could do to save Selene. Flavio's wife—Ember's mom—had finally passed into the deep azure, where she would finally be free of the Shadowrot that had torn her life away.